JUNE 2026

The Six Percent Report: Inside the Companies Making Enterprise AI Work

THE BEHAVIORS BEHIND SUCCESSFUL ENTERPRISE AI, AND WHAT OTHERS CAN DO TO FOLLOW



A REUTERS INSIGHTS REPORT, PRODUCED IN PARTNERSHIP WITH SCALE AI

scale | Reuters Insights

Contents

Foreword **3**

Key Takeaways **5**

Methodology **6**

How We Define the Six Percent **7**

Key Statistics **9**

The Six Percent: The New Enterprise AI Leaders **10**

The Hallmarks of AI Success **12**

Answering the Build or Buy Question **16**

Data as a differentiator **20**

How the Six Percent are Building on AI Success **22**

Eight Moves to Join the Six Percent **25**

Disclaimer: This content was produced by Reuters Insights, our commercial research division; Reuters news staff had no role in its production.

Foreword

In just a few years, AI has changed what people can learn, create and achieve on their own. For individuals, the transformation is tangible and accelerating. For the large organizations that underpin modern society, turning that promise into durable operational value has proven far more difficult. The recent explosion of generative AI has driven unprecedented investment in AI programs across virtually every major industry, but investment alone has not translated into transformation. Pilots have multiplied, but many have not graduated to production. Promising tools have stalled at the point of integration. Organizations have found themselves investing at full force without the returns to show for it.

This matters for everyone. The enterprises where AI is succeeding or stalling are not peripheral players. They are the hospitals managing patient care, the financial institutions allocating capital, the logistics networks moving goods, and the infrastructure operators keeping essential services running. When AI delivers in these environments, the benefits compound across entire economies. When it does not, the cost is measured not just in wasted budgets, but also in regulatory exposure, compliance risk, eroded trust, and outcomes that affect the people and communities these organizations serve.

In an effort to help close the AI success gap for enterprises, this report profiles the organizations getting AI to work at scale and the characteristics that set them apart.

Together, we surveyed 494 senior AI decision-makers across major enterprises to understand what separates the organizations successfully deploying AI from those whose programs have stalled. Within that sample, we identified the ***Six Percent***: a group of 32 organizations that meet three demanding criteria simultaneously:

- AI is thoroughly integrated across most business functions
- More than half of their AI pilots have reached full production
- Their AI programs are advancing faster than expected and delivering value at scale.

What the ***Six Percent*** have in common is specific and, in most cases, repeatable. They treat data infrastructure as a strategic decision, not a procurement line item. They are more likely than the broader market to combine internally-developed tools with external platforms, and to hold a strategic vendor relationship or partnership, rather than buy ready-made tools off the shelf. Across the wider sample, off-the-shelf or standardized tools with no modifications are around two and a half times as common among stalled deployments as among successful ones.

And while the broader market is only now committing to agentic AI (AI systems that can reason, plan, use tools, and act across enterprise workflows toward a defined business goal); the ***Six Percent*** have already deployed it and are moving on to more complex, sector-specific rollouts. Notably, two-thirds of successful deployments put in place by the ***Six Percent*** show a measurable business result within six months.

Each of these characteristics is examined in the chapters ahead. The patterns we describe are associations, not proven cause and effect: a cross-sectional survey can show what distinguishes the organizations getting AI to work, not prove that any single characteristic produced the result. Read that way, the findings still offer something the wider AI discourse rarely provides - for any organization that has run a pilot, funded a deployment, or chosen a vendor in the past 18 months, a clear-eyed account of what the most successful enterprises share, and concrete steps any enterprise can weigh for its own AI transformation.

We would like to thank all those who participated in our study, and hope the pages that follow help close that gap. The ***Six Percent*** are pulling ahead. The distance is still closeable. But the window is narrowing.

*By **Emily Xue**, Head of Enterprise AI, Scale AI, and **Liam Stoker**, Head of Market Insights, Reuters Insights*



Key Takeaways

For an at-a-glance look at what the Six Percent report covers, here are the highlights. Each takeaway is explored in depth, with the underlying data, in the chapters ahead. These are characteristics associated with enterprises that have found success in their AI programs, not a guarantee that any single one produces results on its own.

WHO ARE THE SIX PERCENT:

Most enterprises are still figuring out AI. But a small group, just 6% of the 494 large organizations we surveyed, have cracked it. These 32 companies share three things: AI is thoroughly integrated across most functions, the majority of their pilots have made it to production, and they are significantly ahead of their own internal targets. We call them the ***Six Percent***, and this report is about what they do differently.

THEY MOVE FASTER:

Speed is one of their greatest advantages. Pilots tend to reach production in under six months, and two-thirds see measurable business outcomes within six months of starting, more than twice the rate of the broader sample.

THEY FRONTLOAD THE HARD WORK:

Before any return is expected, they have executive sponsorship locked in, their data is organized, and training and change management underway. The broader market is still retrofitting these after the fact.

THEY BUILD AND BUY DIFFERENTLY:

They are more likely to combine internal builds with external platforms (hybrid approach), and when they bring in a vendor, they want deep co-development or a fully managed service, not an off-the-shelf tool with minimal customization.

THEY TREAT AI LIKE A BUSINESS PRIORITY, NOT A TECHNOLOGY PROJECT:

From budget allocation to vendor selection to how they measure success, the ***Six Percent*** have embedded AI into how the business actually runs, not just how IT and technology teams operate.

WHAT IT TAKES TO FOLLOW:

The report closes with eight concrete moves any enterprise can make. The window is still open, but the ***Six Percent*** are pulling ahead. The distance is closeable, but the decisions need to be made now, not after the next pilot.

Methodology

The *Reuters Insights AI Deployment Survey* was conducted online in Q2 2026. A total of 494 senior decision-makers qualified and completed the survey. To qualify, respondents had to be directly responsible for, or a key decision-maker in, AI strategy, deployment, procurement or evaluation; work for an organization that is actively piloting AI or has AI in production; sit in technology/IT, business operations, data/AI/analytics or strategy/transformation; hold a director/head-of-function, VP/SVP/EVP or C-suite/board role; work for an organization headquartered in the US and Canada, Europe (incl. the UK) or the Middle East; and report organizational revenue of $51m or more.

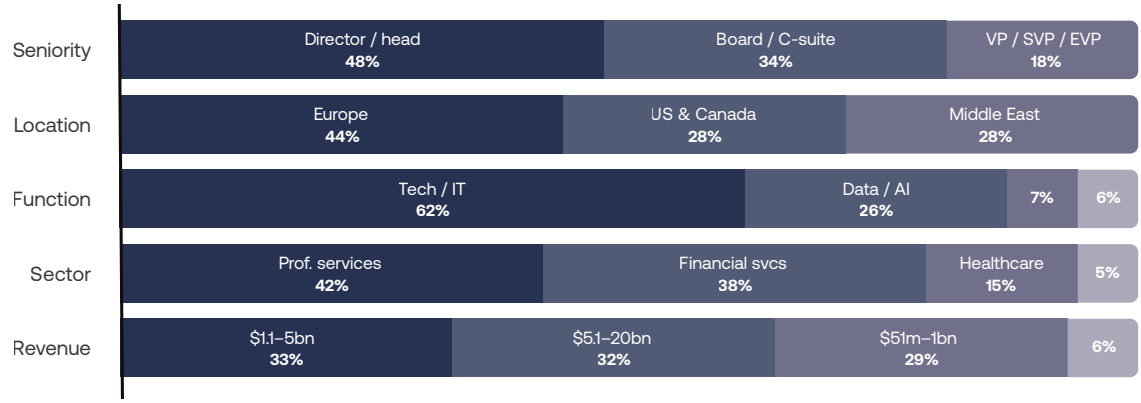
Of the 494 respondents, 34% were board members or C-suite executives, 18% were VP/SVP/EVP and 48% were directors or heads of function. By role location, 44% were in Europe, 28% in the US and Canada and 28% in the Middle East. By primary function, 62% sat in technology/IT, 26% in data, AI or analytics, 7% in strategy/transformation and 6% in business operations.

By sector, respondents worked in professional services (42%), financial services (38%), healthcare and life sciences (15%) and insurance (5%). By revenue, 29% reported $51m–$1bn, 33% $1.1bn–$5bn, 32% $5.1bn–$20bn and 6% above $20bn.

Data was gathered following standard market-research guidelines. Significance testing was conducted at the 95% confidence level. Where a difference between the ***Six Percent*** and the broader sample is small relative to the size of the cohort, we say so in the text rather than presenting it as a headline; see the note on the ***Six Percent*** cohort below.

Unless otherwise stated, full-sample figures are reported on the 494 respondents; outcome questions that apply only to organizations with a successful deployment are reported on that subset (n=421). As with any survey, results may not represent the views of every enterprise deploying AI.

SURVEY RESPONDENT PROFILE



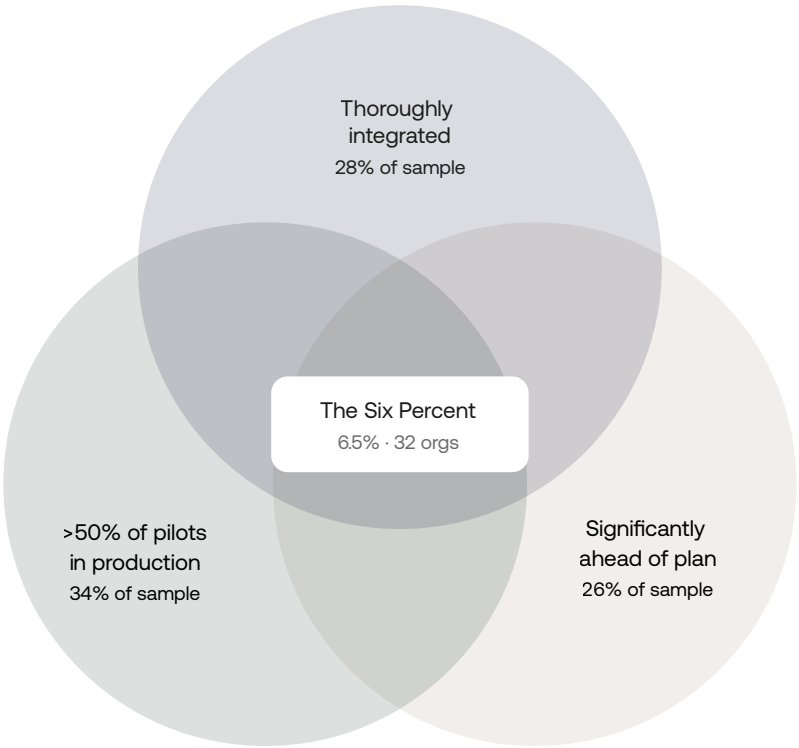
Source: Reuters Insights' Enterprise AI Deployment Study (2026)

How We Define the Six Percent

Because this analysis rests on a single cohort, it is worth being precise about who they are, how the terms are defined, and what a sample of this size can and cannot show.

THE SIX PERCENT: THREE CRITERIA, MET AT ONCE

32 of 494 organizations (6.5%) clear all three simultaneously



Source: Reuters Insights' Enterprise AI Deployment Study (2026)

Thirty two of the 494 respondents (6.5%) meet all three criteria. We refer to them as the ***Six Percent*** throughout. “Functions” means the nine business functions profiled against within our survey, including sales & marketing; customer service & support; finance & procurement; legal & compliance; HR & talent; operations & supply chain; IT & software development; product development & R&D; and executive decision support.

“Measurable business outcome” means one of the outcomes in a separate question within our survey (for example, a reduction in operational cost, an increase in revenue or pipeline conversion, an improvement in retention or in output quality) achieved on the respondent’s most successful deployment.

HOW TO READ THE SIX PERCENT NUMBERS

Small cohort:

the ***Six Percent*** is a 32-respondent subset. Each respondent is worth roughly three percentage points, so figures move in large steps - 78% is about 25 respondents, 66% is about 21, and 56% is about 18. Smaller differences between the ***Six Percent*** against the broader sample below should be read as directional.

Association, not cause:

this is a cross-sectional survey. Where we say the ***Six Percent*** "differ" or are "distinguished by" something, we mean an observed association. Causal relationships between variables and outcomes are better established using other research methods, including randomized controlled experiments, natural experiments, and case studies employing process tracing. It is our goal for this study to suggest a cluster of variables for future studies on AI project success to delve into, as opposed to providing a definitive answer. We hope that this study will spark conversations and inspire new research avenues.

Because the cohort is defined on outcomes, it is fair to ask whether the ***Six Percent*** are simply the largest or best-resourced organizations in the sample, in which case their practices would be a consequence of scale rather than a model others could follow. However when analyzing revenue, sector and region the ***Six Percent*** looks much like the full sample; where they differ is seniority, with half being C-suite or board members against a third of the sample.

Profile	The Six Percent (n=32)	Full sample (n=494)
Revenue $1.1bn or above	72%	70%
Revenue $5.1bn or above	47%	38%
C-suite / board respondents	50%	34%
Professional services	50%	42%
Financial services	34%	38%
Headquartered in US & Canada	34%	28%

Profile of the 6% against the full sample (Q5, Q7, Q3, Q6a). Read alongside the n=32 caveat above: each percentage point is roughly one respondent.

Key Statistics



Thirty-two of the 494 organizations surveyed meet all three criteria for making enterprise AI work at scale. Everyone else is somewhere behind them, and the gap is widening.



Two-thirds of the ***Six Percent*** record a measurable business outcome within six months of a pilot starting. Among the broader successful-deployment sample, fewer than one in three move that fast.



More than four in ten of the ***Six Percent's*** most successful builds are hybrid - internal build combined with external platforms - nearly three times the rate of the broader sample.



Eight in ten of the ***Six Percent*** are extremely confident their data foundations can support AI, against a third of the broader sample.



Almost nine in ten of the ***Six Percent*** expect AI investment to rise significantly over the next 12 months, against 43% of the broader sample.



More than three-quarters of the ***Six Percent*** report an improvement in customer retention or satisfaction from their most successful deployment - the joint most-cited outcome for the cohort.

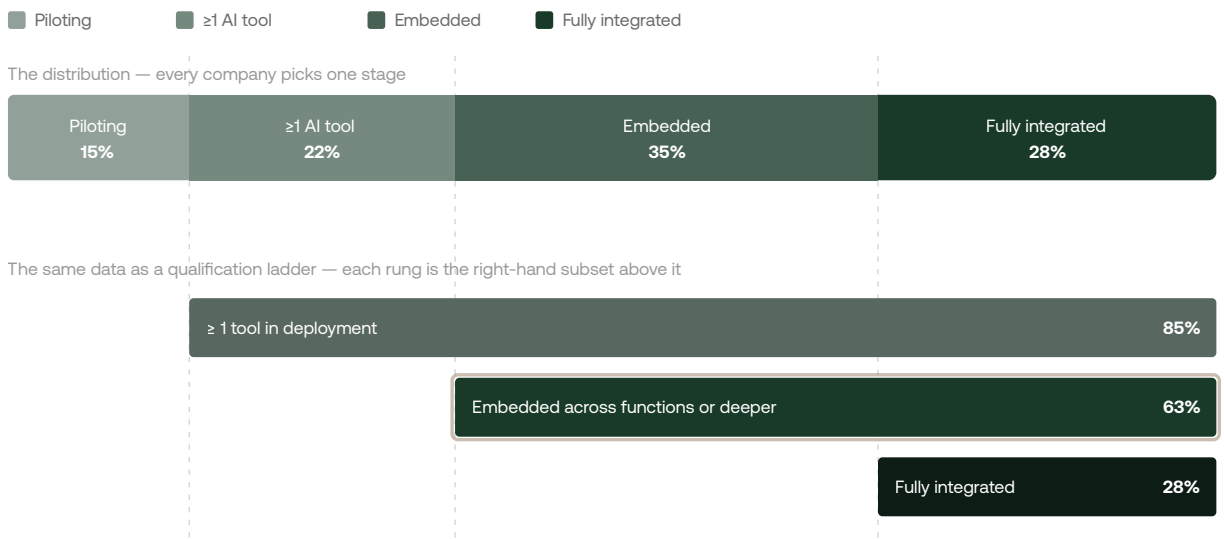
The Six Percent: The New Enterprise AI Leaders

A year ago, the question hanging over AI adoption in most boardrooms was a defensive one. The conversation between the CIO and the CFO may have been dominated by the need for the technology to show results: how much of our AI spend is in the failing column? What does our pilot-to-production rate look like against the benchmark? Are we already behind?

Across our survey, 32 respondents - 6.5% of the total sample of 494 – answered all three of those questions positively: AI is being used frequently across most of their business, more than half of AI pilots have been converted to production, and progress is significantly ahead of their own, internally-set targets or expectations. We call them the ***Six Percent***. What they share is a shift in the underlying question, from whether enterprise AI works to how to get the next pilot into production faster than the last.

This shift is visible at scale. More than a quarter (28%) of enterprises in our sample now describe their AI deployment as thoroughly integrated across most functions, with AI central to how they operate and compete. A further 35% say AI is embedded across multiple functions and is demonstrably impacting business performance. Together, this 63% represents the group for whom AI is no longer experimental, but has become part of how the business actually runs.

FIGURE 1: AI IS EMBEDDED OR THOROUGHLY INTEGRATED FOR NEARLY TWO-THIRDS OF ENTERPRISES IN ACTIVE DEPLOYMENT



Source: Reuters Insights' Enterprise AI Deployment Study (2026)

HOW THE SIX PERCENT USE AI

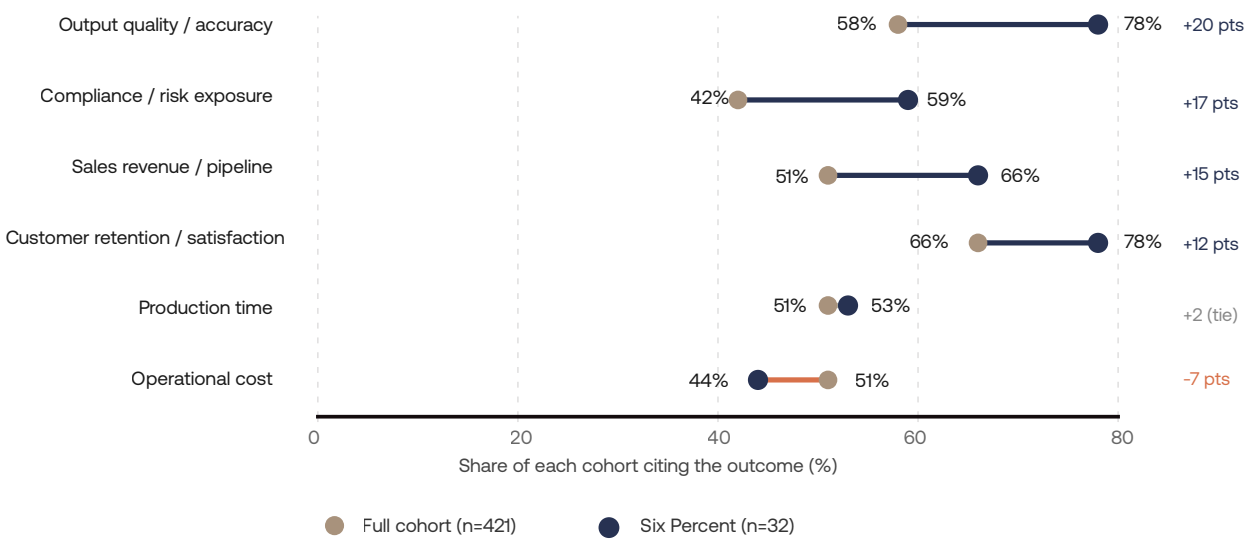
By definition, the ***Six Percent*** sit at the deepest end of the deployment scale. They all describe AI as thoroughly integrated across most functions and central to how the organization operates and competes. By comparison, 28% of our full sample state as such, while 35% state that AI is embedded across multiple functions.

The business outcomes follow a coherent pattern. Asked which measurable outcomes their most successful deployment achieved, the ***Six Percent*** return higher rates than the broader sample on almost every category.

Among the ***Six Percent***, 78% have indicated their most successful AI deployment led to improvement in customer retention or satisfation scores.

The shift in how success is defined is itself a finding. Alternative benchmarks, including McKinsey's State of AI surveys and BCG's Build for the Future series, leant on adoption metrics, productivity proxies and strategic narratives. The ***Six Percent*** are reporting against the same scorecard the rest of the business runs on, including revenue, cost and quality. They have done the harder organizational work of building AI into the company accounts.

FIGURE 2: THE SIX PERCENT GENERATE REVENUE AND MANAGE RISK; THE BROADER MARKET IS STILL MAKING THE COST-REDUCTION CASE



Source: Reuters Insights' Enterprise AI Deployment Study (2026)

The Hallmarks of AI Success

What separates the ***Six Percent*** most clearly from the rest of the market is speed. They run faster, ship faster and see results more quickly.

Among the ***Six Percent***, 53% move pilots to full production within six months - almost double the 30% of our broader cohort who report the same pace of development. Two-thirds of the ***Six Percent*** (66%) see a measurable business outcome inside six months from pilot start, against fewer than a third (31%) of the broader successful-deployment sample. Equally, the ***Six Percent*** are more likely to have demonstrated success close to a single quarter than a year, while the inverse is true of our broader sample.

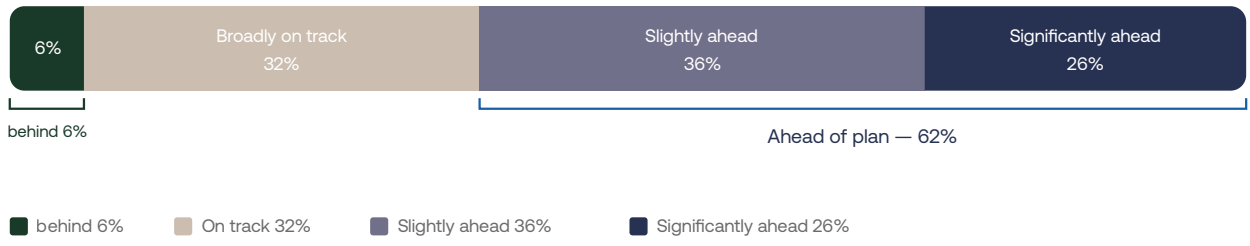
This chapter describes how that capability gap has widened.

WHERE THE MARKET IS NOW

The starting point is perhaps more obvious than the past year of AI coverage and headlines might suggest. Among the 494 enterprises with active AI programs, 85% now have at least one AI tool running in production. The pilot-only state - actively piloting, none yet in production - is a minority position.

A year on from the MIT NANDA report which captured that just 5% of organizations had moved from pilot to production with success, this report shows that enterprise AI can move past the pilot phase successfully. The remaining question is one of pace and depth, and that question separates the ***Six Percent*** from the broader market more sharply than the deployment-status data alone reveals.

FIGURE 3: MOST ORGANIZATIONS SAY THEY ARE AHEAD OF THEIR OWN PLAN; ONLY THE SIX PERCENT ARE SIGNIFICANTLY SO



Source: Reuters Insights' Enterprise AI Deployment Study (2026)

Across the broader sample, 62% of organizations describe themselves as ahead of expectations with regards to scaling AI over the past 18 months, with 26% reporting this to be significantly ahead.

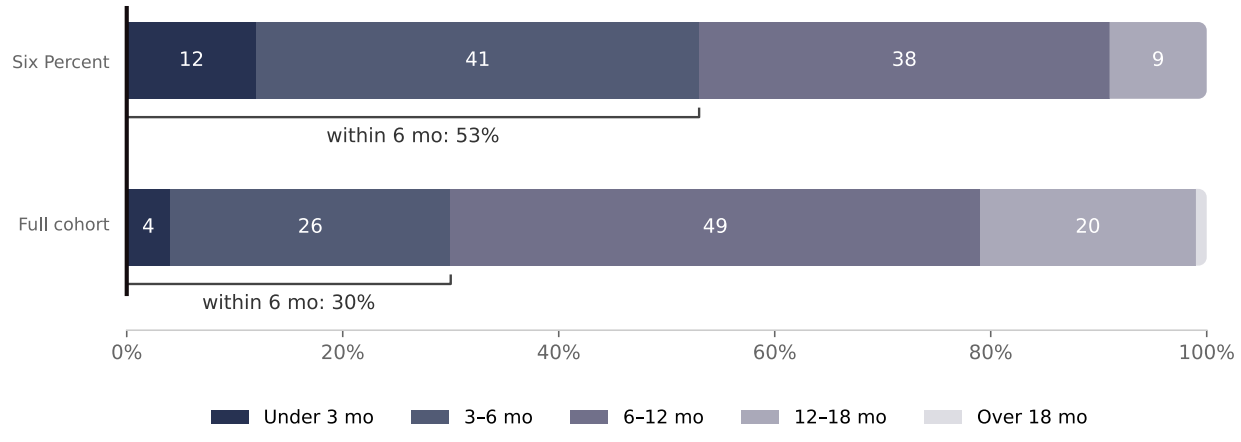
The forward investment direction confirms the same picture. More than four in five organizations across the broader sample (87%) expect AI investment to increase over the next twelve months, 43% do so significantly. Among the ***Six Percent***, the picture is sharper: a significant majority (88%) expect a significant increase, with fewer than 10% expecting just a slight increase. Where the full sample is broadly committed to expanding AI investment, the ***Six Percent*** are committed to expanding it more aggressively. AI is no longer a marginal line item for either group, but for the ***Six Percent*** it has become a defining capital priority.

INSIDE THE PATH TO PRODUCTION

The pilot-to-production timeline is the metric for success on which the Leaders' speed advantage is perhaps most visible. Across the broader sample of those who had recorded successful deployments – linked to our survey question discussing the respondent's most successful AI deployment to date - the typical pilot-to-production timeline sits at six to twelve months for nearly half of respondents, and at three to six months for a further quarter.

Among the ***Six Percent***, the distribution is shifted forward by a full period: 41% of this group move pilots to production within three to six months, while a further 12% move quicker still. Indeed, our full sample was twice as likely to report pilots taking longer than a year to move into production than the ***Six Percent,*** encapsulating the pace at which they have come to work. The ***Six Percent*** are running the same operational process the broader sample is running, but the cycle time has been compressed by 40 to 50%.

FIGURE 4: THE SIX PERCENT'S TYPICAL PILOT REACHES PRODUCTION IN UNDER SIX MONTHS; FOR THE REST OF THE MARKET IT TAKES LONGER



Source: Reuters Insights' Enterprise AI Deployment Study (2026)

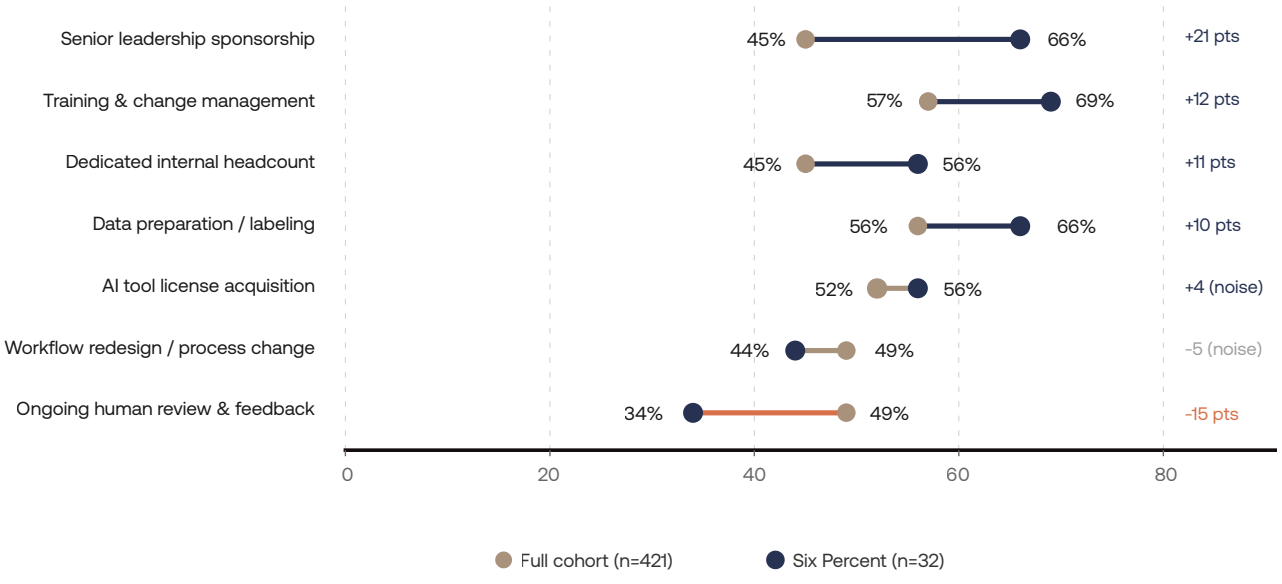
The compression is sharper still on the speed at which our respondents realized time-to-business-outcome. Among the ***Six Percent*** group, 22% saw measurable business outcomes within three months of starting a pilot, while just 6% of the broader sample indicated the same. A majority (66%) of the ***Six Percent*** report measurable outcomes within six months, more than twice the occurrence within the broader sample. The ***Six Percent*** see business results from AI faster than most companies' budget cycles allow them to even check on progress. The ***Six Percent*** have synched the pace of their AI work with the pace at which their boards review it, and no longer have to justify slow progress against a financial calendar that was never designed for AI.

That pace is at least partly explained by what the ***Six Percent*** commit to before meaningful business value was realized. The most-cited resourcing drivers for the ***Six Percent*** are training existing employees and change management, data preparation and labelling work, and senior leadership time and sustained executive sponsorship. For all three, greater shares of the ***Six Percent*** indicated that they were present than across our broader sample.

- Training existing employees and change management
- Data preparation and labelling work
- Senior leadership time and sustained executive sponsorship

The AI-related resource commitments most-cited by the ***Six Percent.***

FIGURE 5: THE SIX PERCENT FRONTLOAD THE HARD WORK; THE REST OF THE MARKET IS STILL PAYING FOR NOT DOING SO



Source: Reuters Insights' Enterprise AI Deployment Study (2026)

The ***Six Percent*** would also appear to be investing more substantial portions of their IT budgets, with more than half of this group indicating that the most successful AI deployment was allocated 11 – 20% of their organization's overall IT budget. The ***Six Percent*** are funding AI as a serious capital priority, not as a side project.

However the accelerator question, or what single change would most accelerate the move from pilot to production, produces an interesting divergence in behaviors that separates the ***Six Percent*** from the rest of the sample.

Across the full sample, three answers cluster at the top, each within half a percentage point of the others: clear governance and compliance frameworks (15.4%), standardized processes (15.2%) and employee training (15.0%).

For the ***Six Percent,*** governance is still present (19%), but tools/technology rises sharply: 22% of this group identify better tools and technology as the single greatest accelerator, against 11% of the broader sample. Executive leadership support, by contrast, drops to zero among the ***Six Percent***, against nine percent of the broader sample. In other words, the ***Six Percent*** did not cite leadership as the most important factor that would accelerate the pace at which their organization successfully deploys AI.

That observation has implications for vendor positioning. AI tools sold on small technical improvements (faster speeds, lower running costs, marginally better accuracy) are competing for budgets organizations have already committed elsewhere. The vendors winning budget decisions are those positioning themselves as partners in the architectural and capability-extension work, not as suppliers of the underlying model layer. The next chapter takes up that procurement question directly.



Answering The Build or Buy Question

Every enterprise AI buyer arrives, sooner or later, at one procurement question on which the rest of the program turns: build it ourselves, buy it from a vendor, or do both? The ***Six Percent*** do two things differently:

They are markedly more likely than our broader sample to combine tools built in-house with external platforms, rather than committing to any single procurement model. When they do involve a vendor, they favor either deep co-development of tools, with both parties sharing ownership of the outcomes, or signing up to a fully -managed service. For this group, a middle ground where the buyers sets the roadmap for the vendor to provide solutions for is not desirable.

HOW WE USE THE BUILD/BUY TERMS

Build: built entirely in-house using internal engineering and data teams.

Buy - off-the-shelf: procured from an external vendor and deployed with little or no customization.

Buy - customized: procured from an external vendor and significantly customized to the organization's workflows.

Co-develop: built jointly with an external vendor in a partnership model, with shared input into the product.

Hybrid: a deliberate combination of internal build and external components - some parts built in-house, others bought or co-developed - rather than a single approach.

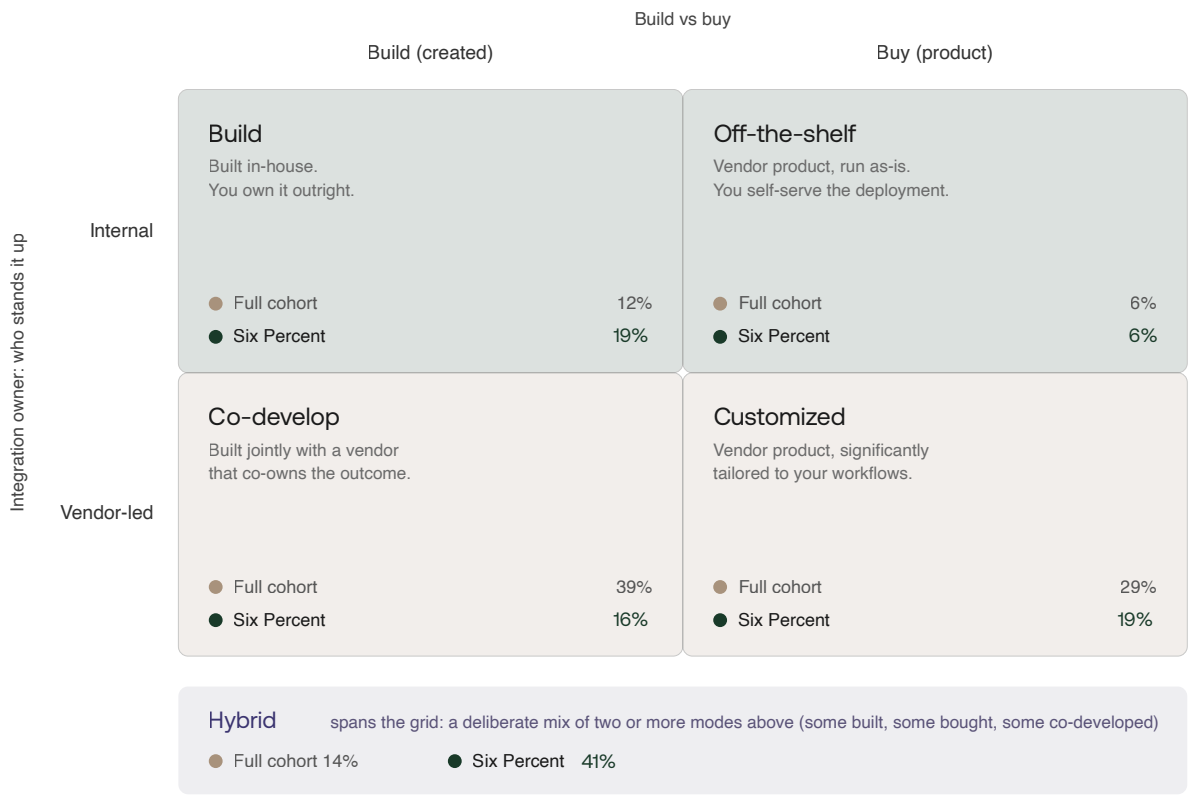
When referring to build, buy and co-development options, these five terms specify how we have surveyed audiences on *how AI deployment is built*. They are distinct from the question of *what kind of vendor relationship* an organization wants (software provider, implementation partner, strategic partner or managed service), which we treat separately.

HOW THE SIX PERCENT BUILD

Asked how their most successful deployment was built and delivered, the broader sample's most common single answer is co-development with an external vendor, at 39%. The ***Six Percent*** diverge sharply: a hybrid of internal build and external components is their single most common approach, at 41% - nearly three times the occurrence within the broader sample. In other words, while the broader market's default is to pick one particular way to build, most often co-development, the ***Six Percent*** deliberately combine multiple approaches.

The ***Six Percent*** are not distinguished by co-developing more than everyone else - they co-develop less. What sets them apart is building in a hybrid fashion: in-house where they have the engineering capability, customized vendor products where an existing platform fits, and a combination where neither pure model does.

FIGURE 6: FOUR IN TEN OF THE SIX PERCENT'S SUCCESSFUL BUILDS ARE HYBRID; THE BROADER MARKET STILL PICKS ONE MODEL



Source: Reuters Insights' Enterprise AI Deployment Study (2026)

OFF-THE-SHELF RARELY SITS BEHIND THE SUCCESSES

Off-the-shelf tools – those we consider ready-made, deployed with little or no customization - appear at very different rates on the two sides of the divide. Among organizations whose most successful deployment was a single identifiable project, just six percent built it off-the-shelf. Among organizations that have seen pilots stall, off-the-shelf was the dominant approach for 15%.

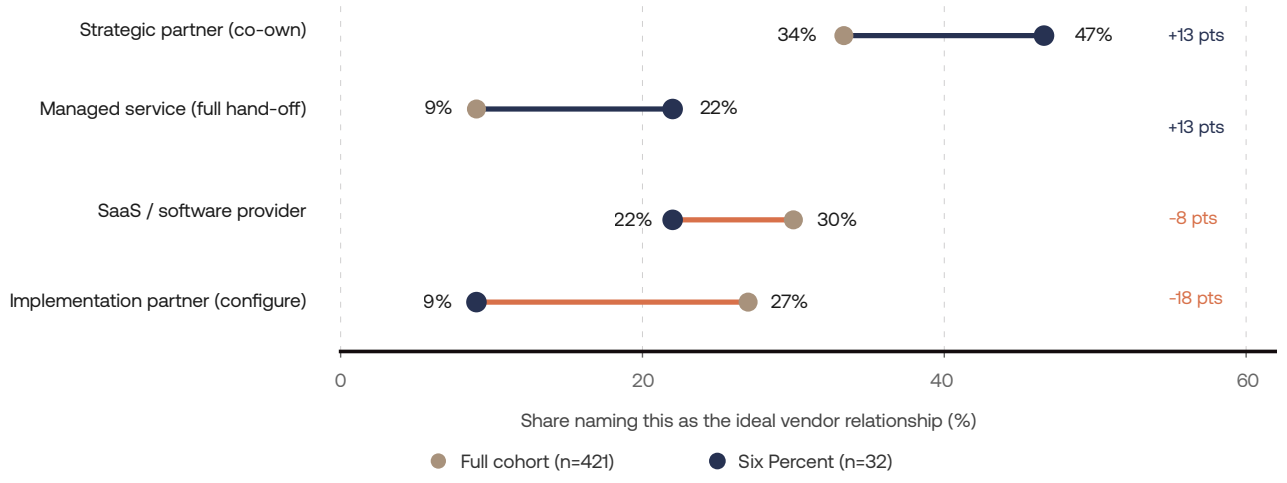
The survey doesn't let us follow a fixed set of off-the-shelf projects to see how many succeeded or failed - these are two separate readings, not a like-for-like rate - but the contrast is consistent across the rest of the build data: off-the-shelf is conspicuously rare among the successes and conspicuously present among the stalls.

WHAT KIND OF VENDOR RELATIONSHIP THE SIX PERCENT WANT

Separate from how a deployment is built is the kind of relationship the buyer wants with a vendor. Here the ***Six Percent*** are mostly found at two ends of that vendor relationship spectrum: nearly half (47%) want deep co-development with a strategic partner, sharing ownership of outcomes, and a further 22% want a fully managed service the vendor runs end-to-end.

What they avoid is the middle ground, where the buyer specifies the roadmap and the vendor configures the tool. Across the full sample, strategic partner is the most common preference at 34%, followed by software provider (30%) and implementation partner (27%), with managed service least common (9%).

FIGURE 7: THE SIX PERCENT WANT FULL CO-OWNERSHIP OR FULL HAND-OFF, WITH LITTLE APPETITE FOR SOMETHING IN BETWEEN



Source: Reuters Insights' Enterprise AI Deployment Study (2026)

This is further supported by where vendor support is most valued. Across the full sample, 42% rate a vendor's support for AI development and usage at the top level of importance, and 90% rate it in the top two. The ***Six Percent*** place even greater weight on it - 88% rate it the highest level - a procurement-design statement that, for this group, vendor support is a structural condition of the partnership rather than a service-level add-on.

On selection criteria, the two groups rank closely, with two shifts worth noting. Integration with an organization's existing technology choices and clear data security and governance commitments lead across the sample. The ***Six Percent*** lean harder on integration - their most-cited first-choice criterion - and on an established vendor relationship, a sign they are extending relationships they have already chosen rather than looking to shop elsewhere.

On the evidence here, how you buy AI is among the highest-stakes decisions in an enterprise AI program. It comes before the technology choices and shapes the governance, and for the ***Six Percent*** it is not a single contract signed once, but a series of architectural decisions taken as the tech stack – or the combination of chosen platforms - evolves.



Data as a Differentiator

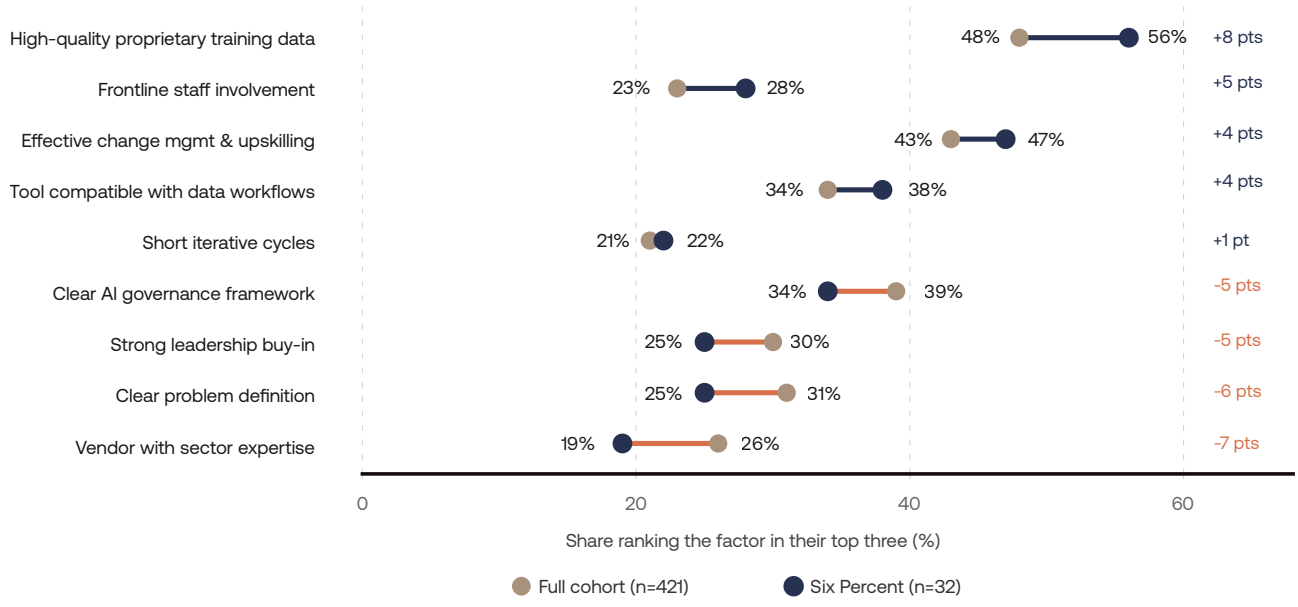
Asked what made their most successful AI deployment work, the ***Six Percent*** point first to data. How they find and manage that data is what sets them apart in ways that are not always obvious, and that change how every other company should think about choosing a vendor.

WHY THE SIX PERCENT CITE DATA FIRST

That headline finding is sharpened by deeper analysis of our data. High-quality proprietary data used for AI model training appears in more than half (56%) of the ***Six Percent's*** top-three rankings of the most important factors in successful deployment, compared to 48% across the broader sample.

Effective change management and upskilling sits at 47% for the ***Six Percent*** group against 43% for the broader sample. Tool compatibility with existing data workflows sits at 38% for the ***Six Percent***. Clear AI governance frameworks sit at 34% for the ***Six Percent***, marginally below the 39% for the broader sample. Those within the ***Six Percent*** have put governance into operational practice rather than naming it as a critical success factor in retrospect.

FIGURE 8: PROPRIETARY DATA TOPS THE SIX PERCENT'S SUCCESS FACTORS AND OUTRANKS EVERY OTHER FACTOR FOR THE COHORT



Source: Reuters Insights' Enterprise AI Deployment Study (2026)

Where the groups diverge sharply is confidence. A significant majority (81%) of the ***Six Percent*** are extremely confident their data foundations can support AI, against 34% of the broader sample - one of the largest single gaps in the study. Adding the next tier produces a near-unanimous picture for the ***Six Percent*** (97% extremely or very confident) against a still-strong 83% for the broader sample.

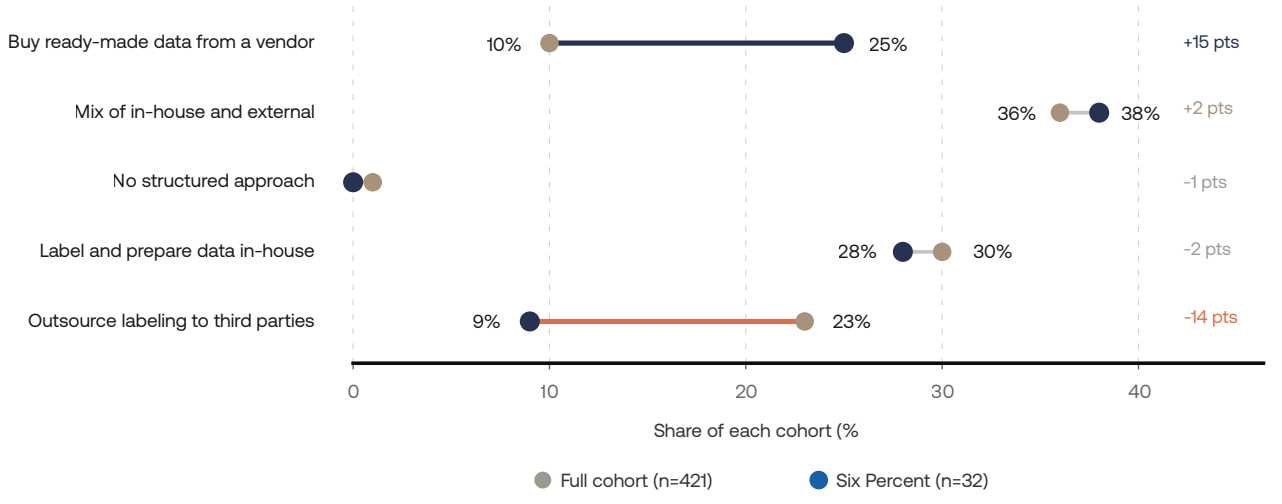
WHERE THE SIX PERCENT GET THEIR DATA

Every AI system runs on a data layer, and agentic systems are no exception. Even when the model is a pre-trained foundation model, it still needs curated domain data to ground its retrieval, evaluate its outputs, and tune its behavior. Who builds that data layer, the buyer or a vendor, is a real strategic choice.

The two cohorts answer it differently in one specific way. A hybrid of internal and external data work is the most common approach for both, at 38% of the ***Six Percent*** and 36% of the broader sample. The difference is in how the rest is handled. When the ***Six Percent*** go external, they are more likely to buy a finished data product from a single vendor (25% versus 10%) and less likely to run labeling through third-party services (nine percent versus 23%). They avoid assembling the data layer from piecemeal labeling contracts and source it as an integrated product instead.

For buyers, the lesson is one of sequence. The data layer is a decision to make early, before the model and the use case are locked, because it shapes everything that follows.

FIGURE 9: THE SIX PERCENT CONCENTRATE DATA WORK WITH ONE STRATEGIC PARTNER RATHER THAN SPREADING IT ACROSS LABELLING VENDORS



Source: Reuters Insights' Enterprise AI Deployment Study (2026)

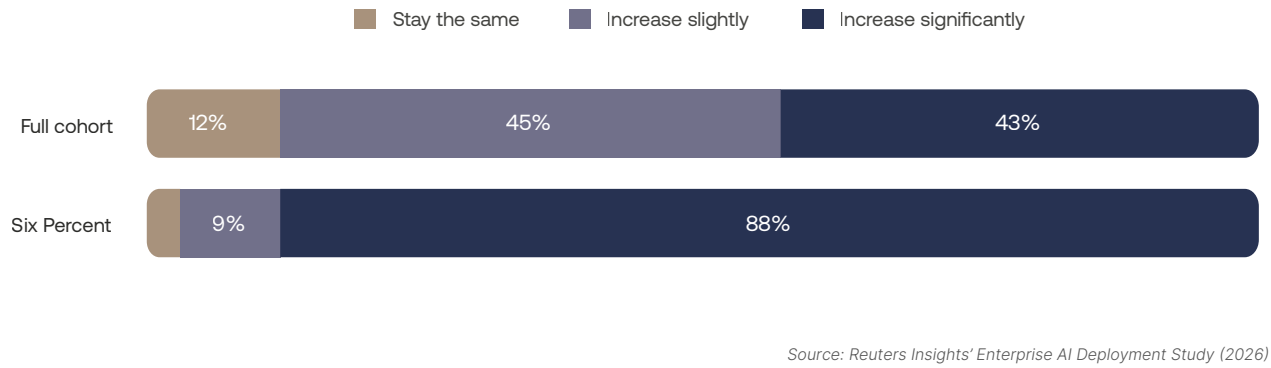
How the Six Percent are Building on AI Success

Twelve months from now, the AI investment market will look meaningfully different from the one this research describes today. The forward investment trajectory is not in serious doubt - almost nine in ten organizations expect AI investment to rise, and a substantial minority expect it to rise sharply.

What remains in doubt is whether the ***Six Percent*** and others are heading in the same directions or continuing to diverge. The evidence available within our research would indicate a divergence is happening.

The headline forward-investment number is large at both cohorts. More than four in five organizations across the broader sample (87%) expect AI investment to increase over the next twelve months, with 43% expecting a significant increase. Among the ***Six Percent***, the picture is sharper still: 88% expect a significant increase, with just 9% expecting a slight one. Not only is AI investment growing faster among the ***Six Percent***, but where the money is going is also changing, and that matters more for buyers than the headline growth number.

FIGURE 10: THE BROADER MARKET EXPECTS AI INVESTMENTS TO RISE. THE SIX PERCENT EXPECT THEM TO SURGE.



Source: Reuters Insights' Enterprise AI Deployment Study (2026)

WHERE THE SIX PERCENT ARE GOING NEXT

The category each cohort identifies as the heaviest single forward-investment bet tells the story most clearly. Across the broader sample, two categories sit level at the top of heaviest-investment intent: AI-integrated productivity suites at 19% and workflow automation and agentic AI platforms at 19% - within half a percentage point of each other.

For the ***Six Percent***, however, that picture is different. Productivity suites lead heavily-invested intent at 31%, while specialist vertical AI tools,

including industry-specific applications in legal, finance and healthcare, are also more popular for this group than our broader survey cohort.

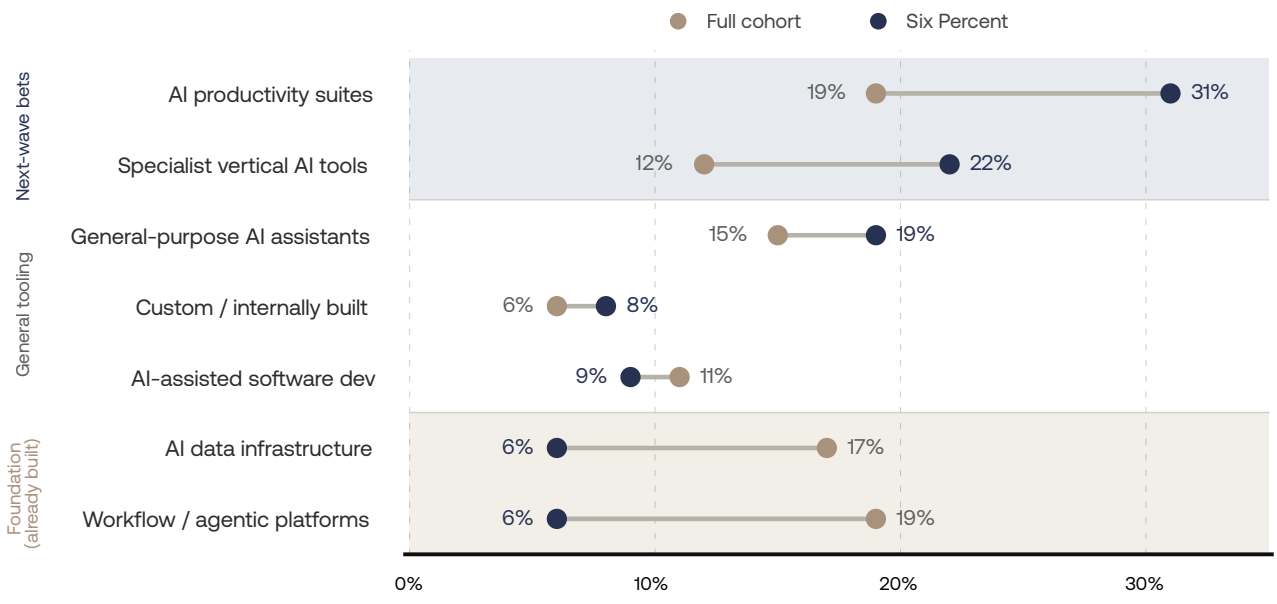
The ***Six Percent*** already use and evaluate these platforms heavily but they are not buying more of them. The most likely reason is that they have already bought what they need at the foundation level, and are now focused on getting more value out of the tools they have built on top.

The ***Six Percent*** are evidently consolidating on previous success, extending the value of productivity-suite deployments already in production and reaching deeper into the regulated and vertical-specific applications that complete the operational picture.

The broader sample's market, meanwhile, is a new-platform market: making the agentic and workflow-automation platform investment the ***Six Percent*** have largely already made, and continuing to fund the data infrastructure layer they have largely already concentrated. Neither cohort is wrong about its respective forward bet, they are simply at different points on the same journey.

Use-case priorities reinforce the same divergence. Across the broader sample, data analysis and business intelligence is the dominant single use-case priority for the next twelve months at 62%. Among the ***Six Percent***, it is also the most-cited priority, at 60%. But the ***Six Percent***'s other top priorities (AI for sales and marketing, and AI for finance, legal and compliance work) are well above

FIGURE 11: THE BROADER MARKET IS MAKING ITS AGENTIC AI BET WHILE LEADERS HAVE ALREADY MADE THEIRS



Source: Reuters Insights' Enterprise AI Deployment Study (2026)

the broader sample. The wider market is still laying the foundations, while the ***Six Percent*** are already deciding which second-wave use cases will deliver the next round of value.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR BUYERS ENTERING THE MARKET

For buyers entering the market today, the question the data raises is which investment path to follow. The ***Six Percent***'s path is the benchmark, but following it requires the architecture, executive sponsorship and data foundations they have already built.

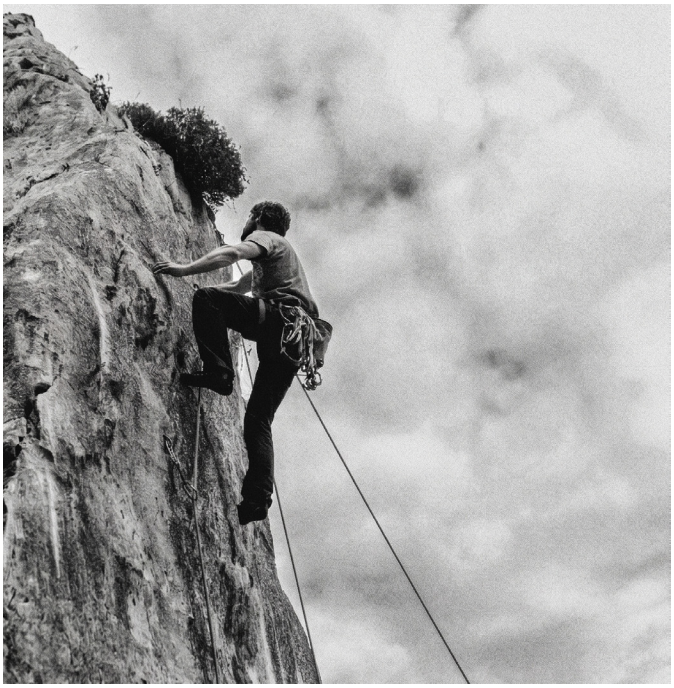
The broader sample's trajectory is closer to a realistic near-term roadmap for organizations earlier in the maturity curve: building out the agentic and workflow-automation platforms the ***Six Percent*** have already deployed, continuing to invest in the data infrastructure layer, and waiting for the productivity-suite and vertical-AI consolidation phase to follow.

AI data infrastructure platforms sit at 17% of heaviest forward-investment intent in the broader sample or third overall, behind productivity suites and agentic platforms. Among the ***Six Percent***, the figure drops substantially. While this may look as if this group are buying less data infrastructure, our findings in the whole would instead suggest they have simply already procured it. The near-50% usage rate and the 25% reliance on vendor-supplied training data tell the same story: the ***Six Percent*** have already consolidated the data layer with the right partner, or partners, in place and are now running that relationship rather than re-procuring it. The category's next growth wave does not come from the ***Six Percent***, but from the broader sample catching up.

That is, in miniature, the picture of this report. The ***Six Percent*** have done the foundational work - on data, on procurement architecture, on executive sponsorship, on measurement - and moved on to the next problem, while our broader cohort is still building the foundations.

The gap between the two groups is not primarily a technology gap. The ***Six Percent*** are not running materially different models or accessing tools the rest of the market cannot reach. What separates them is a sequence of organizational decisions, most of them taken before a line of code was written or a vendor was signed. Get the sponsorship in place, commit the budget at platform scale, choose the data infrastructure partner before the model vendor and proceed along a workflow design made long before deployment began. This is measured against the organizational P&L from the beginning.

None of those decisions is technically complex, but all of them would be harder to achieve than appears written on paper. The ***Six Percent*** have made them. The question for every other organization in this research - and the question this report exists to answer - is what it would take to follow.



Eight Moves to Join the Six Percent

*Drawing on the survey data and the characteristics of the **Six Percent**, here are eight moves any enterprise can consider to give its AI program the best chance of success. Each cites the finding it draws on. They describe what the most successful enterprises have in common, but they are not a guarantee that any single move produces success on its own.*

LAY THE GROUNDWORK

1

Anchor executive ownership before you fund the pilot

Sustained executive sponsorship and a named business owner are among the most-cited commitments behind deployments that succeeded. Pilots funded from a departmental line, without a sponsor whose attention extends past procurement, are likelier to stall.

2

Plan and resource for a multi-quarter pilot-to-production cycle

Across the broader successful-deployment sample, only around three in ten saw a measurable outcome within six months; nearly half took six to twelve months. Programs expecting a return within a single quarter are systematically under-resourcing the build phase. The investment case has to clear a longer horizon than the procurement cycle that funds it.

3

Start the agentic shift now

Workflow-automation and agentic platforms already attract forward-investment intent close to that of productivity suites across the market, and the ***Six Percent*** have largely deployed them already. Organizations still treating agentic AI as a future problem risk arriving late.

BUILD THE TEAM AND THE PARTNERSHIPS

4

Buy a partner, not just a product - and be wary of the off-the-shelf default

Off-the-shelf tools are conspicuously rare among the successes - six percent of organization's most successful deployments - yet were the dominant approach for 14% of those whose pilots stalled. The ***Six Percent's*** distinguishing build choice is a hybrid of internal and external components (41% of their successful builds, against 14% of the broader sample), and their preferred vendor relationships sit at the ends of the spectrum: deep co-development or fully managed service.

5

Spend on people at least as heavily as on software

Training and change management is the single most-cited commitment behind successful deployments, and across the market employee training and adoption ranks among the top accelerators of pilot-to-production pace. A larger license deal will not unblock an unprepared organization.



MEASURE YOUR MILESTONES

6

Redesign the workflow before go-live, not after

Around half of organizations with a successful deployment cite workflow redesign or process change before go-live as a required commitment. Deploying first and redesigning afterwards produces exactly the integration failures that dominate stalled.

7

Get data in order before you scale the model

High-quality proprietary data is the most-cited success factor overall, yet only 17% of organizations name AI infrastructure and data foundations as a top investment priority for the next 12 months - the lowest of ten use-case categories.

8

Test, evaluate and keep improving

The most common definition of AI success in the sample is a measurable improvement in a specific business KPI; strategic positioning, executive satisfaction and adoption also feature, but the pull is toward measurable business outcomes. Organizations defining success against “strategic alignment” alone trail those that have moved to P&L attribution. What distinguishes the strongest programs is not a one-off launch test but a discipline of evaluation - extensive, often industry-specific benchmarking before deployment, then continuous monitoring and improvement once live, with human feedback used to keep model output on track.